

A catalogue of money mistakes

We all know that there's catharsis and comfort in knowing that we're not alone in our struggles and errors, and so that's what I want to offer to you to help you to move forward with this first step. One of the biggest components that I found was keeping me locked in that horrible feeling of shame and despair, solidifying that self-diagnosis of myself as hopeless with money, was feeling that I was alone in my mistakes. Knowing that I wasn't, and seeing people I liked and respected, people in a huge variety of situations and from a huge variety of different backgrounds, admitting to experiencing the same challenges as me was a huge catalyst for change.

When I deliver workplace talks or consultations, the first exercise that I do with participants is to ask them to think of three mistakes they've made with money, big or small. I then encourage them to share with the group – and one of two things will happen. Rarely, people keep their cards very close to their chest and there is little to no activity – understandable, as work can be a very difficult place to be vulnerable – but what usually happens is that one person is brave enough to go first, and then the dominoes fall. People talk about money that they lent and never got back, money that they wasted, credit card balances that they regret and everything in between, and it feels like there is a collective sigh of relief. The more people reveal, the better everyone feels, and the happier they are to discuss their own relationship with money, in a sort of positive snowball effect.